

How the mighty fall

Microsoft has knelt before the courts. At least for the time being. The world's largest software manufacturer, and best known in the recent past for its much publicised fight with the US Department of Justice, has offered to include rival software on CDs.

And if you are happy about it, you should thank European Union (EU) anti-trust regulators who said Microsoft has violated competition rules by tying its media player software to Windows. EU is considering asking Microsoft to offer two different versions of its operating system, one with audio and video playback features and one without them. EU is considering this to give consumers more choices over audio and video playback software.

The EU, always known for its policy of doing everything that Americans do, did the same in this case. Instead of attacking Microsoft by focusing on browsers (like the Americans did), EU concentrated on the Windows Media Player. And it won.

EU has also indicated that it will make sure that big PC makers are free to choose what multimedia software they want to install on new PCs. Whoa! Where does that leave Microsoft now? Wait and watch.

snapshot

Worldwide sales of camera phones expected to reach 150 million in 2004

Source: InfoTrends Research Group

The Bagle has sounded; run for cover

Though the Beagle project for Mars exploration may have not got what it really wanted, the Bagle Internet virus has no full stops. Since its inception mid-January, it has as many as 16 variants even as we go to print.

Bagle's ingenuous way of affecting a PC by enforcing a backdoor entry has troubled hundreds of network administrators. It spreads by scanning the PC and all shared folders with names starting with 'shar', for any lists of e-mail addresses, and then mailing the infection to these addresses.

The virus spoofs the domain name of the recipient. Therefore, a person would feel that the e-mail came from someone within his domain such as the

administrator, or from his friend (by his e-mail ID found on his PC).

It compresses the infected file inside a password protected zip file. The password is provided in the e-mail body. Virus scanners responded by 'reading' the password, and using it to decompress the attachment and weeding out the virus.

Virus developers soon



Find the Bagle removal tool on the Mindware CD

created a new variant—the password was now

part of an image, something that Yahoo or Hotmail give you to verify your account while signing up. Anti-virus firm Symantec, meanwhile, has claimed that it can delete this virus even without referring to the image.

The chase continues.

tomorrow's technology

Net speed demon

A new Internet data protocol developed at the North Carolina State University may well have what's needed to give truly amazing speeds for data transmission.

Called Binary Increase Congestion-TCP (BIC-TCP), the new protocol was tested alongside six other competing protocols at the Stanford Linear Acceleration Center, and was judged on top on several parameters including stability, scalability and fairness in comparison to the others.

BIC works by using a binary search algorithm to search for maximum network capacity within mini-

mal data loss. It means that such a protocol can be used for large scale scientific studies in nuclear and high energy physics, astronomy, geology and meteorology. BIC-TCP can deliver speeds that can work out to 6000 times the throughput available from today's DSL lines or 1,50,000 times faster than a modem connection.

Co-developer Injong Rhee says what TCP can do in two hours, BIC can do in less than a second. That's an impressive statistic for what might become a dominant protocol on tomorrow's Internet.

quoteworthy

"These alleged cures would make matters worse... if foreigners were to retaliate, we would surely lose jobs"

US Federal Reserve chairman Alan Greenspan, who feels protectionist measures would damage the US economy.

"We think this as the next evolution in mobile entertainment...for the same money as an audio-only player, you will be getting video as well"

James Bernard, Portable Media Center product manager, Microsoft. Microsoft plans to launch portable entertainment devices with 40 GB capacity running Windows software by the year-end in Europe.

"... unchecked spread of open-source software, under the GPL (the General Public License) is a much more serious threat to our capitalist system"

Dale McBride, CEO, SCO in a message sent to the members of the US Congress earlier this year. SCO threatened to launch legal action against the Lawrence Livermore National Laboratory and the National Energy Research Scientific Computing Center (NERSC), over the use of "unlicensed" Linux-based supercomputers.